

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

----- X

MICHAEL RIVERS,

Plaintiff,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER
RAYMOND RUSSO, Shield No. 17553, LIEUTENANT
ASHRAF AHMED, DETECTIVE TRISTON TRUNK,
Shield No. 3628, and POLICE OFFICERS JOHN DOES #s
1-10 (names and numbers of whom are unknown at
present),

Defendants.

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SUMMONS

Index No.:

The Basis of Venue is:
Location of IncidentPlaintiff designates Kings
County as the place of trial.**To the above-named Defendants:**

You are hereby summoned to answer the complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorneys within twenty days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: New York, New York
February 8, 2022

Yours, etc.



JACOBS & HAZAN, PLLC
DAVID M. HAZAN, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
30 Vesey Street, 4th Floor
New York, New York 10007
(212) 577-2690TO: City of New York, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007
POLICE OFFICER RAYMOND RUSSO, Shield No. 17553
LIEUTENANT ASHRAF AHMED, 78th Precinct, 65 6th Ave, Brooklyn, Ny 11217
DETECTIVE TRISTON TRUNK, Shield No. 3628, Criminal Intelligence Section

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INDEX NO.:

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

Plaintiff MICHAEL RIVERS, by his attorneys, Jacobs & Hazan, PLLC, as and for his Verified Complaint herein, alleges upon information and belief as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights action to recover money damages arising out of defendants' violation of plaintiff's rights as secured by the Civil Rights Act, 42 U.S.C. Sections 1983 and 1988, and of rights secured by the First, Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, and the common law and the laws of the State of New York. Plaintiff alleges that on February 8, 2019, at approximately 5:00 am he was lawfully visiting his family and was present in the living room of his mother's apartment located at 1067 Belmont Street, 1st Floor, Brooklyn, New York 11208 when the individually named defendants unlawfully broke open the front door of the apartment, entered the apartment, unlawfully searched plaintiff and the entire apartment, and falsely arrested plaintiff, without probable cause or legal justification. At no time relevant herein did defendants recover any illegal drugs, weapons, or contraband from plaintiff's possession, custody, or control. Nevertheless, the defendants unlawfully handcuffed plaintiff and transported him to the 63rd Precinct against his will whereat he was unlawfully searched, fingerprinted, photographed, interrogated, and detained in a filthy holding cell for many hours. Defendants provided the Kings County District Attorney's Office with false, misleading, and incomplete evidence and allegations about the evidence they allegedly recovered from the apartment that purportedly formed defendants' basis for arresting plaintiff. Specifically, defendants failed to inform the District Attorney's Office that plaintiff did not live in the apartment or that he was at the apartment visiting family. Additionally, the defendants failed to inform the District Attorney's Office that the illegal items that they allegedly recovered from the apartment

were allegedly recovered from inside of closed containers located in rooms where the defendants never observed plaintiff present and in locations that the defendants lacked any evidence to support allegations that plaintiff had access to or control over. The defendants also failed to inform the District Attorney's Office that they did not possess any evidence whatsoever to support any allegations against plaintiff that he had possession, custody, or control over any of the illegal items allegedly recovered by defendants from the apartment on February 8, 2019. Plaintiff was transported to Kings County Central Booking whereat the unlawful detention continued for many additional hours. On February 9, 2019, a criminal prosecution was initiated against plaintiff without probable cause based upon the false, misleading, and incomplete evidence provided by the defendants and contained in the criminal court complaint that was executed by defendants. On February 9, 2019, plaintiff was arraigned in Kings County Criminal Court and charged with crimes he did not commit and for which defendants lacked probable cause to accuse him of committing. At no time relevant herein did plaintiff commit a crime, or violate the law in any manner, nor did defendants possess an objective factual basis to establish probable cause to accuse plaintiff of committing a crime or violating the law in any manner. Plaintiff was released from custody on his own recognizance at arraignment. He was required to return to Kings County Criminal Court on approximately 2 occasions to address the false charges brought against him. On or about March 8, 2019, all charges brought against plaintiff were dismissed and sealed in their entirety. Plaintiff was deprived of his constitutional and common law rights when the individual defendants unlawfully frisked, searched, interrogated, falsely arrested, and denied plaintiff the right to due process/ right to a fair trial in violation of the Fourth, Fifth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, the common law, and the laws of the State of New York.

PARTIES

2. Plaintiff MICHAEL RIVERS is a resident of the state of New York.
3. Defendant POLICE OFFICER RAYMOND RUSSO, Shield No. 17553, is and was at all times relevant herein, an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.
4. Defendant POLICE OFFICER RAYMOND RUSSO, Shield No. 17553, was at all times relevant herein, assigned to the 63rd Precinct.
5. Defendant POLICE OFFICER RAYMOND RUSSO, Shield No. 17553, is being sued in his individual and official capacity.
6. Defendant LIEUTENANT ASHRAF AHMED, is and was at all times relevant herein, an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.
7. Defendant LIEUTENANT ASHRAF AHMED, was at all times relevant herein, assigned to the 63rd Precinct and is currently assigned to the 78th Precinct.
8. Defendant LIEUTENANT ASHRAF AHMED, is being sued in his individual and official capacity.

9. Defendant DETECTIVE TRISTON TRUNK, Shield No. 3628, is and was at all times relevant herein, an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.

10. Defendant DETECTIVE TRISTON TRUNK, Shield No. 3628, was at all times relevant herein, assigned to the 63rd Precinct and is currently assigned to the Criminal Intelligence Section.

11. Defendant DETECTIVE TRISTON TRUNK, Shield No. 3628, is being sued in his individual and official capacity

12. Defendant New York City Police Officers John Does #s 1-10 are and were at all times relevant herein officers, employees, and agents of the New York City Police Department.

13. Defendants New York City Police Officers John Does #s 1-10 are being sued in their individual and official capacities.

14. At all times relevant herein, the individual defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees, and officers of the New York City Police Department, and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the New York City Police Department at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents and employees of the New York City Police Department and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees, and agents of the New York City Police Department.

15. Defendant City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department, which acts as its agent in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible. The defendant City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the New York City Police Department.

16. This action falls within one or more of the exceptions as set forth in CPLR Section 1602, involving intentional actions, as well as the defendant, and/or defendants, having acted in reckless disregard for the safety of others, as well as having performed intentional acts.

17. Plaintiff has sustained damages in an amount in excess of the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts of the State of New York.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

18. On February 8, 2019, at approximately 5:00 am he was lawfully visiting his family and was present in the living room of his mother's apartment located at 1067 Belmont Street, 1st Floor, Brooklyn, New York 11208 when the individually named defendants unlawfully broke open the front door of the apartment, entered the apartment, unlawfully searched plaintiff and the entire apartment, and falsely arrested plaintiff, without probable cause or legal justification.

19. At no time relevant herein did defendants recover any illegal drugs, weapons, or contraband from plaintiff's possession, custody, or control.

20. The defendants unlawfully handcuffed plaintiff, without probable cause or legal justification.

21. Defendants searched the entire apartment, damaged property in the apartment during the search, and created an enormous mess in the apartment which took plaintiff's mother several days to clean up.

22. At all times relevant herein plaintiff was present in the living room of the apartment.

23. Defendants admit that they did not recover any illegal drugs, weapons, or contraband from plaintiff's person.

24. Defendants admit that they did not recover any illegal drugs, weapons, or contraband from the living room of the apartment where plaintiff was located.

25. Defendants falsely alleged that they recovered illegal drugs and ammunition from inside of closed containers recovered from a room where plaintiff was not present.

26. The defendants knew that plaintiff did not live in the apartment and was present because he was visiting family, and they listed plaintiff's home address on the paperwork they filled out regarding plaintiff's arrest.

27. Although defendants failed to recover any illegal drugs, weapons or contraband from plaintiff's possession, custody, or control, and lacked probable cause to believe plaintiff committed a crime or violated the law in any manner, the defendants unlawfully handcuffed and falsely arrested plaintiff.

28. Defendants transported plaintiff to the 63rd Precinct, against his will, whereat he was unlawfully searched, fingerprinted, photographed, interrogated, and detained in a filthy holding cell for many hours.

29. Defendants provided the Kings County District Attorney's Office with false, misleading, and incomplete evidence and allegations about the evidence they allegedly recovered from the apartment that purportedly formed defendants' basis for arresting plaintiff.

30. Defendants failed to inform the District Attorney's Office that plaintiff did not live in the apartment or that he was at the apartment visiting family.

31. Additionally, the defendants failed to inform the District Attorney's Office that the illegal items that they allegedly recovered from the apartment were allegedly recovered from inside of closed containers located in rooms where the defendants never observed plaintiff present.

and in locations that the defendants lacked any evidence to support allegations that plaintiff had access to or control over.

32. The defendants also failed to inform the District Attorney's Office that they did not possess any evidence whatsoever to support the allegations against plaintiff had possession, custody, or control over the illegal items allegedly recovered by defendants from the apartment on February 8, 2019.

33. Plaintiff was transported to Kings County Central Booking whereat the unlawful detention continued for many additional hours.

34. On February 9, 2019, a criminal prosecution was initiated against plaintiff without probable cause based upon the false, misleading, and incomplete evidence provided by the defendants and contained in the criminal court complaint that was executed under the penalty of perjury by defendants.

35. On February 9, 2019, plaintiff was arraigned in Kings County Criminal Court and charged with crimes he did not commit and for which defendants lacked probable cause to accuse him of committing.

36. At no time relevant herein did plaintiff commit a crime, or violate the law in any manner, nor did defendants possess an objective factual basis to establish probable cause to accuse plaintiff of committing a crime or violating the law in any manner.

37. Plaintiff was released from custody on his own recognizance at arraignment.

38. Plaintiff was required to return to Kings County Criminal Court on approximately two (2) occasions to address the false charges brought against him.

39. On or about March 8, 2019, all charges brought against plaintiff were dismissed and sealed in their entirety.

40. At no time relevant herein did plaintiff commit a crime, or violate the law in any manner, nor did defendants possess an objective factual basis to establish probable cause to accuse plaintiff of committing a crime or violating the law in any manner.

41. Defendants falsely arrested plaintiff, without probable cause or legal justification.

42. Defendants violated plaintiff's right to due process when they provided the District Attorney's Office with false, misleading, and incomplete evidence which formed the basis for initiating the criminal prosecution against plaintiff.

43. At no time relevant herein did defendants recover any illegal drugs, weapons, or contraband from plaintiff's possession, custody, or control.

44. At no time relevant herein did plaintiff commit a crime or violate the law, nor did defendants possess objective facts that would lead a reasonable police officer to believe he possessed probable cause to believe plaintiff committed a crime or violated the law.

45. Plaintiff was deprived of his constitutional and common law rights when the individual defendants unlawfully searched, questioned, frisked, and falsely arrested plaintiff in violation of the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, the common law, and the laws of the State of New York.

46. Those officers that did not physically touch plaintiff but observed their fellow officers violating plaintiff's rights under New York State law and the Constitution but neglected to intervene to stop their fellow officers from continuing to violate plaintiff's rights under New York State law and the United States Constitution are liable to plaintiff for their failure to intervene.

47. The individually named defendant police officers have significant histories of having complaints filed against them by members of the public for engaging in police misconduct as NYPD police officers and violating the Constitutional Rights of members of the public, but the discipline by the NYPD on each of those occasions was insufficient to prevent the officers from continuing to engage in such misconduct because the NYPD does not sufficiently investigate allegations that a police officer violated the Constitutional Rights of an individual and did not sufficient punish defendants for the misconduct they previously engaged in.

48. Numerous complaints and lawsuits have been filed against the individually named defendants by members of the public throughout their careers, but most of the time the NYPD conducted a cursory investigation into the complaints and concluded that it did not possess enough evidence to determine whether defendants engaged in misconduct and therefore did not discipline them for many of the complaints made against them.

49. Defendants have continued to violate the Constitutional Rights of members of the public because they never suffered any significant consequences for engaging in the unlawful behavior in the past and apparently feel as if they can continue engaging in the unlawful behavior without any serious consequences.

50. The deliberate indifference by the NYPD and defendant City of New York towards its officers and defendants when they engage in such unlawful and unconstitutional behavior is the proximate cause of plaintiff's injuries because defendants knew that there would not be any consequences for violating plaintiff's rights and engaging in the unlawful conduct since the City of New York and the NYPD are deliberately indifferent when NYPD officers behave in that manner.

51. Given defendants' histories of allegations of violating the Constitutional Rights of members of the public, defendants should not have been patrolling the streets of New York and/or supervising other officers at the time of plaintiff's arrest in this case, and plaintiff's rights may not have been violated if the defendant City of New York had properly investigated and disciplined defendants and other officers throughout the NYPD prior to the date of plaintiff's arrest in this case.

52. The City of New York is deliberately indifferent to and fails to properly address situations when NYPD officers have engaged in police misconduct and violated the rights of members of the public.

53. The unlawful search, false arrest, false imprisonment, malicious prosecution, and denial of the right to due process/ a fair trial by the individually named defendants caused plaintiff to sustain physical, psychological, economic, and emotional trauma.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Plaintiff's Fourth Amendment and Fourteenth Amendment Rights

54. The plaintiff repeats reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 53 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

55. The individually named police officer defendants while acting in concert and within the scope of their authority, unlawfully entered and searched plaintiff's mother's apartment, caused plaintiff to be unlawfully searched, frisked, questioned, seized, denied due process, falsely arrested, and falsely imprisoned, without probable cause, in violation of plaintiff's right to be free from an unreasonable seizure under the Fourth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest and False Imprisonment

56. The plaintiff repeats reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 55 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

57. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute false arrest and false imprisonment under the laws of the State of New York. Defendants intended to confine plaintiff and, in fact, confined plaintiff, and plaintiff was conscious of the confinement. In addition, plaintiff did not consent to the confinement and the confinement was not otherwise privileged.

58. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

59. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

60. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, economic, emotional, and psychological injuries.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Search

61. The plaintiff repeats reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 60 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

62. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop and search inside plaintiff's pockets and underneath his clothing, employed by defendants herein, and terminated plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

63. Defendants lacked probable cause to search plaintiff.

64. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

65. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

66. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Denial of Due Process and the Right to Fair Trial

67. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs numbered 1 through 66 with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

68. Defendants, individually and collectively, falsified, manufactured and/or withheld evidence and forwarded this false evidence to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

69. Defendants filled out false and misleading police reports and forwarded them to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

70. Defendants signed false and misleading criminal court affidavits and forwarded them to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

71. In withholding/creating false evidence against plaintiff, and in providing/withholding information with respect thereto, defendants violated plaintiff's constitutional right to a fair trial under the New York State Constitution and under the Due Process Clause of the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

72. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiff, sustained, inter alia, loss of liberty, emotional distress, embarrassment and humiliation, anxiety, and deprivation of her constitutional rights.

73. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

74. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene

75. The plaintiff repeats reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 74 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

76. Defendants had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

77. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein.

78. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiff's liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, he was put in fear of her safety, and he was humiliated and subject to other physical constraints.

79. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION**Municipal Liability under 42 U.S.C. § 1983 for Policy of Deliberate Indifference When NYPD Officers Violate the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution**

80. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 79 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

81. Plaintiff was unlawfully searched, interrogated, frisked, falsely arrested plaintiff, and denied plaintiff then right to due process without an objective factual legal basis to seize, arrest and prosecute plaintiff pursuant to an unconstitutional policy and practice of the NYPD that is deliberately indifferent to the fact that many NYPD officers, including defendants engage in this type of misconduct on a regular basis without being disciplined and/ or retrained.

82. There is a policy, practice, or custom within the New York City Police Department, wherein New York City Police Officers illegally frisk, search, interrogate, falsely arrest, and fabricate evidence, without a specific, articulable factual basis supporting a reasonable suspicion or probable cause to believe the individual had violated any law or ordinance.

83. The NYPD and defendant City of New York are deliberately indifferent to the fact that its police officers persistently and pervasively continue to unlawfully and unconstitutionally violate the Fourth, Fifth, and Fourteenth Amendment Rights of members of the public.

84. Defendant City of New York is liable to plaintiff for the damages he suffered stemming from the unlawful frisk, search, interrogation, and false arrest of plaintiff because defendant City of New York is deliberately indifferent about its police officers' unlawful and unconstitutional behavior when NYPD officers unlawfully search, and falsely arrest members of the public when there is no factual basis to suspect the individual has committed a crime.

85. The City of New York has been deliberately indifferent about the fact that its police officers have been engaging in said unconstitutional behavior and the NYPD has not taken reasonable steps to ensure its police officers do not continue to engage in this unconstitutional behavior, through discipline or retraining police officers who engage in this behavior and violate the law and the Constitution of the United States.

86. The deliberate indifference by the NYPD and defendant City of New York towards its officers when they engage in such unlawful and unconstitutional behavior is the proximate cause of plaintiff's injuries because the officers knew there would not be any consequences for violating plaintiff's rights and engaging in the unlawful conduct since the City of New York and the NYPD are deliberately indifferent when NYPD officers behave in that manner.

87. As a result of defendant City of New York and the New York City Police Department's policy wherein New York City Police Officers illegally and unconstitutionally, search, and falsely arrest individuals without a specific, articulable factual basis supporting a reasonable suspicion or probable cause to believe the individual had violated any law or ordinance, and the New York City Police Department's deliberate indifference about the fact that New York City Police Officers routinely continue to conduct these searches, arrests, and criminal prosecutions, without reasonably articulable suspicion and/or probable cause, there is a pattern, policy, custom or practice of New York City Police Officers searching, falsely arresting and maliciously prosecuting individuals without a factual basis supporting a legal reason to do so.

88. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, engaged in conduct that constituted a custom, usage, practice, procedure, or rule of defendant City of New York, which is forbidden by the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

89. The aforementioned customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules devised, implemented, enforced, promoted, encouraged, and sanctioned by the City of New York, including but not limited to : (a) the failure to adequately and properly screen, train, and supervise New York City Police Officers; (b) the failure to properly and adequately monitor and discipline New York City Police Officers; and (c) the overt and tactical encouragement and sanctioning of, and the failure to rectify, the New York City Police Departments suspicionless seizures, searches, arrests, and prosecutions.

90. The City of New York has acted with deliberate indifference to the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment rights of plaintiff and other individuals. As a direct and proximate result of the acts and omissions of the City of New York, plaintiff has been deprived of her rights under the Fourth, Fifth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution.

91. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of defendant City of New York and the New York City Police Department were the moving force behind the Constitutional violations suffered by plaintiff as alleged herein

JURY DEMAND

92. Plaintiff hereby demands trial by jury of all issues properly triable thereby.

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, plaintiff Michael Rivers demands judgment against the defendants on each cause of action in amounts to be determined upon the trial of this action which exceeds the jurisdiction of lower courts, inclusive of punitive damages and attorneys' fees inclusive of costs and disbursements of this action, interest, and such other relief as is appropriate under the law. That the plaintiff recover the cost of the suit herein, including reasonable attorney's fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988.

Dated: New York, New York
February 8, 2022

By: David Hazan
DAVID M. HAZAN
JACOBS & HAZAN, PLLC
Attorneys for Plaintiff
30 Vesey Street, 4th Floor
New York, NY 10007
(212) 577-2690

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

DAVID M. HAZAN, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the State of New York, affirms the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

I am a partner of the law firm of **JACOBS & HAZAN, PLLC**, I have read the annexed **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters therein which are stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. My belief, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, is based upon facts, records, and other pertinent information contained in my files. The reason this verification is made by me and not plaintiff is because plaintiff does not reside in the county wherein I maintain my office.

DATED: New York, New York
February 8, 2022

David Hazan

DAVID M. HAZAN